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ESSENTIAL ENGLISH GRAMMAR

Conform To The New Program



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ARTICLES

"A, An, The" definite and indefinite articles in English
Here are the rules for when to use "A, An or The":

- a = indefinite article (not a specific object, one of a number of the same objects) with consonants

She has a dog.
I work in a factory.

- an = indefinite article (not a specific object, one of a number of the same objects) with vowels (a,e,i,o,u)

Can I have an apple?
She is an English teacher.

- the = definite article (a specific object that both the person speaking and the listener know)

The car over there is fast.
The teacher is very good, isn't he?

- The first time you speak of something use "a or an", the next time you repeat that object use "the".

I live in a house. The house is quite old and has four bedrooms.
I ate in a Chinese restaurant. The restaurant was very good.

- DO NOT use an article with countries, states, counties or provinces, lakes and mountains except when the country is a collection of states such as "The United States".

He lives in Washington near Mount Rainier.
They live in northern British Columbia.

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It + be + adjective: desirable/ important/ essential/imperative/vital/etc

In all of these examples below with **should**, you can substitute the subjunctive if you want to make it sound more formal or the present simple tense if you want it to be less formal:

- It is essential (that) you **should be given** your medication by a properly qualified nurse. (Or: be given, or are given.)
- For the future well-being of the company, it is imperative (that) he **should resign** now. (Or: **resign**, or **resigns**.)
- It is desirable (that) he **should be retained** in custody, rather than released on bail. (Or: **be retained**, or **is retained**.)
- It is vital (that) he **should receive** some treatment (or **receive**, or **receives**) whether he **be** (or **is**) innocent or guilty of this particular crime.

suggest / recommend / insist / demand

Similarly with these reporting verbs, we can use should, the subjunctive or the normal tense in the that-clause, depending on whether it is appropriate to sound formal or not:

- The government tried to insist (that) all firearms should be handed in without delay. (Or: be handed in, or are handed in.)
- The doctors have recommended (that) he should remain in hospital for a further three weeks. (Or: remain, or remains.)
- I suggested he should leave right now. (Or: leave, or leaves.)

advise / ask / command / instruct / request / require/warn

Note that these reporting verbs do not require should or a that-clause and are normally used instead with a simple infinitive. The issue of whether to use the subjunctive or not with these verbs does not then arise.

- Her mother advised them to be home by ten o' clock.
- They required me to clean the house every Saturday.
- You asked me to let you know how much it would cost.
- I warned him not to swim where there were dangerous currents.

Were is also a kind of subjunctive when it is used with I and **he/she/it** instead of **was** with wish and **if** If we use the more natural was, it will sound more informal.

- I wish I were (or **was**) home now.
- I wish it were (or **was**) the weekend.
- If I were (or **was**) you, I'd get in touch with Veronica before she leaves for Australia
- If I were (or **was**) still living with John, I'd be much better off, but I wouldn't be so independent.

Fixed expressions with the subjunctive

There are a number of fixed expressions which require the subjunctive, including:

Bless you. (Which means: May God bless you.)

Long live our gracious Queen. (The first line of the British National Anthem)

A toast now: **long live** the bride and groom.

I have always supported you financially, but **be that as it may**, I can no longer support your current lifestyle.

If I have to pretend that you no longer exist, **so be it.**

Be that as it may means **whether that is the case or not So be it** means **nothing can or will be done to change that.**



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حي الكتبان، عمارة أ، مدخل 10 محل 23، المحمدية، الجزائر.
الهاتف: 15 00 82 21 021 / 37 96 82 21 021، الناسوخ: 37 96 82 21 021.
البريد الإلكتروني: clicedition@gmail.com

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EXPRESSING WISHES

We can use "wish" to show that we want a situation to be different. The verb after "wish" is one tense back, so that if you are wishing for a different present situation, the tense that follows "wish" is past simple or past continuous. If you are wishing that a past situation was different, the tense that comes after "wish" is past perfect. You can also use "wish" with modal verbs.

Wish and present situations

Situation: I haven't got any money... (Verb "have" in the present simple)
Wish:. I wish I had some money (Verb "have" in past simple)
Situation: I **am going** to London next week. (Verb "to go" in present continuous)
Wish: "I wish I **wasn't going** to London next week." (Verb "to go" in past continuous)
Situation: I **haven't studied** for the test. (Verb "to study" in present perfect)
Wish: "I wish I had studied for the test." (Verb "to study" in past perfect)



Wish with modal verbs

With could to refer to ability
Situation: I **can't** play a musical instrument.
Wish: "I wish I could play a musical instrument."

Wish and past situations

Situation: I **didn't go** on holiday this year. (Verb "to go" is in past simple)
Wish: "I wish I **had gone** on holiday this year. (Verb "to go" is in past perfect.)

With would to refer to habits and free will

there is another structure that you use to talk about actions that take place in the present, but you want them to change in the future. This structure is used to talk about another person, and generally about things you don't like. The structure is wish + would/could + infinitive. For example:
Situation: you phone me so early in the morning
Wish: I wish you wouldn't phone me so early in the morning.

THE SUBJUNCTIVE

The **subjunctive** is used to express intention or proposal about the future. It requires use of the verb in its basic form rather than its normal tense form.

We don't use the **subjunctive** very much in contemporary English unless we wish to sound very formal. With verbs like **suggest, recommend, insist** and adjectives like **important, essential, imperative, crucial, vital**, we often use **should + infinitive** instead of the subjunctive or we can use the normal tense form. The reporting verbs and adjectives above are normally followed by a **that**-clause in which **that** itself is often omitted. Compare the following:

- The doctor recommended (that) he should give up smoking.
- The doctor recommended (that) he give up smoking. (More formal)
- The doctor recommended (that) he gives up smoking. (Less formal)

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- Use an article with bodies of water, oceans and seas -

My country borders on the Pacific Ocean

- DO NOT use an article when you are speaking about things in general

I like Russian tea.

She likes reading books.

- DO NOT use an article when you are speaking about Meals, places, and transport

He has breakfast at home.

I go to university.

He comes to work by taxi.

THE GERUND

FORM AND USE :



The gerund has the same form as the present participle of a verb : (verb + ing)

Ex: watch + ing = watching

Present participle: I am watching TV.

Gerund : watching tv is fun.

Gerund can be used as nouns, subject, or object in a sentence; after prepositions and after certain verbs.

- as the subject of the sentence:

Watching TV is fun.

- as the complement of the verb 'to be':

My favourite hobby is **skiing**

- After prepositions. The gerund must be used when a verb comes after a preposition:

She is good at **painting**.

- This is also true of certain expressions ending in a preposition, e.g. in spite of, there's no point in..:

There's no point in **waiting**.

In spite of **missing** the train, we arrived on time.

- after a number of 'phrasal verbs' which are composed of a verb + preposition/adverb

to look forward to, to give up, to be for/against, to take to, to put off, to keep on:

I look forward to **hearing** from you soon. (at the end of a letter)

When are you going to give up **smoking**?

She always puts off **going** to the dentist.

He kept on **asking** for money.

*These verbs are commonly followed by gerunds.



admit	advise	anticipate	appreciate	attempt	avoid
begin	can't help	complete	consider	delay	deny
discuss	dislike	enjoy	finish	forget	go
hate	hesitate	imagine	intend	keep	like
love	mention	mind	miss	neglect	postpone
practice	prefer	quit	recall	recollect	recommend
regret	remember	resent	resist	risk	start
stop	suggest	threaten	tolerate	try	understand

PREPOSITIONS

1. at/in/on - prepositions of time and place

The prepositions at, in and on are often used in English to talk about places (positions) and times. Sometimes the choice of one over another in a particular phrase or sentence seems arbitrary. However if we analyse patterns of occurrence we can identify key concepts in meaning and usage which consistently apply and can be used as a platform for learning.

1. Prepositions of time

The preposition **at** is used in the following descriptions of time:

- **With clock times:**

My last train leaves at 10:30.

We left at midnight.

The meeting starts at two thirty.

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GIVING ADVICE

There are several different structures that you can use when giving **advice**

- **Should:**

This is probably the most common of the structures for giving advice. After **should**, and its negative - **shouldn't** - we use **the base form of the infinitive of the verb**:



You should wise up
We shouldn't cheat
It is common to use 'I think' and 'I don't think' with should:
I **think** you should **put** the answers back
She **doesn't think** they should **use** them

- **Had better :**

This structure is common in spoken English and it is usually used in **the contracted form**. After **had better**, and its negative - **had better not**, we use **the base form of the infinitive of the verb.**

You'**d better return** the answers to the lecturer.
You'**d better not tell** anyone that you found them

- **If I were you**

This version of the second conditional is often used when giving advice, especially in spoken English. Note the use of **were** with I in the first clause.

In the second clause, we use **would** - contracted to **d** - and **wouldn't**.

After **would** and **wouldn't**, we use **the base form of the infinitive of the verb:**

If **I were you, I'd give** them **back** to the lecturer
If **I were you, I wouldn't use** the answers

- **Ought**

This is the most formal of the structures used for giving advice, and so it isn't so common.

After **ought**, and its negative - **ought not** (oughtn't), we use **the full infinitive of the verb:**

You **ought to contact** the police
You **ought not to cheat** in exams

QUANTIFIERS

Adjectives and adjectival phrases that describe quantity are shown below. Some can only go with countable nouns (friends, cups, people), and some can only go with uncountable nouns (sugar, tea, money, advice). The words in the middle column can be used with both countable and uncountable nouns.

COUNT NOUNS ONLY		COUNT OR NONCOUNT NOUNS	NONCOUNT NOUNS ONLY
each every neither [no]	a dozen fewer several a few few a couple (of)	all most more a lot/lots of plenty of some / any no none	much a great deal of less a little / little
both many a number of hundreds of			

Examples:
All the people in the room were silent.
Both children were born in Italy.
Half (of) his books were in French.
How much money have you got?
How many cigarettes have you smoked?

I've got **a lot of** work this week.
There were **a lot of** people at the concert.
I've got **a few** friends
I've got **a little** money

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We are going to the cinema and spending an evening at the opera. **Coordinating conjunction**
After going to the cinema, we are spending an evening at the opera. **Subordinating conjunction**
The lending library closes at 7pm, but the reading rooms stay open until 9pm. **Coordinating conjunction.**

Whereas the lending library closes at 7pm, the reading rooms stay open until 9pm. **Subordinating conjunction**

The following are common **subordinating conjunctions:-**
Time: after, before, when, while, since, until,
Contrast, Concession, Alternatives: although, though, even if, despite, in spite of, whereas, while
Reason: because, due to, in view of the fact that, since

Time
- after
- after which
- and
- as
- as long as
- as soon as
- at which (point)
- before
- by the time
- hardly*
- no sooner*
- now (that)
- once
- since
- the moment
- then
- till
- until
- when
- whenever
- whereupon
- while

Purpose
- in case
- in order that
- in order to
- so
- so as to
- so that
- to

Result
- consequently
- hence
- and
- thus
- therefore
- and so
- else
- or else
- otherwise
- so
- so that
- as a result/consequence

Contrast, Concession, Alternatives
- although
- apart from
- but
- despite
- even if
- even though
- except that
- in spite of
- or
- much as
- nor
- not that
- though
- whereas
- while
- whilst
- yet

Reason
- as
- as a result of
- because
- because of
- considering
- due to
- for
- given that
- in case
- in view of the fact
- that
- just in case
- on account of
- seeing as/that
- since

Addition
- and
- as well as
- besides
- besides which
- in addition to
- not only

Giving examples
- for instance
- for example
- in particular

showing how to conclude your thoughts
- to conclude
- in brief
- to sum up briefly
- to summarize
- in conclusion

Conditional
- as long as
- even if
- if
- one condition
- that
- provided (that)
- providing (that)
- so long as
- unless
- whether... or

Manner
- as
- as if
- as though
- in a way
- in the way
- just as
- like
- much as
- the way

listing words
- first/firstly
- furthermore
- above all
- moreover
- secondly
- finally/lastly
- last but not least
- next
- thirdly
- one/two/three
- to begin with ...

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You've got a dirty mark on your jumper.
He had a large spot on his nose.
She placed her hand on my shoulder.

- **With roads/streets, or other things that can be thought of as a line, e.g.: rivers:**

Debbie lives on Croft Lane.
The bank is on the corner of King's Street.
Koblenz is on the Rhine.
Bournemouth is on the south coast.
It's the second turning on the left.

The preposition in is used in the following descriptions of place/position:

- **With cities, towns and larger areas:**

Do you like living in Nottingham?
They were having a picnic in the park.
She works somewhere in the toy department.

- **With buildings/rooms and places that can be thought of as surrounding a person or object on all sides:**

Can you take a seat in the waiting room please?
I've left my bag in the office.
There's a wedding in the church this afternoon.
Lots of people were swimming in the lake.

NOUNS and PREPOSITIONS					
approval of awareness of belief in	concern for confusion about desire for	fondness for grasp of hatred of	hope for interest in love of	need for participation in reason for	respect for success in understanding of
ADJECTIVES and PREPOSITIONS					
afraid of angry at aware of	capable of careless about familiar with	fond of happy about interested in	jealous of made of married to	proud of similar to sorry for	sure of tired of worried about
VERBS and PREPOSITIONS					
apologize for ask about ask for belong to	bring up care for find out give up	grow up look for look forward to look up	make up pay for prepare for	study for talk about think about	trust in work for worry about

CONJUNCTIONS AND LINKING WORDS

A conjunction is a word that is used to connect sentences, clauses and phrases. With the help of conjunctions, you can vary the length of sentences in your writing, which will make your writing more interesting and easier to read.
It is important to link words and phrases to integrate them into cohesive writing. The following words and phrases can be used to connect pieces of information in your writing.

Coordinating and Subordinating Conjunctions

Some conjunctions are used simply to join or coordinate clauses, for example, and, but, or, so. Look at the following example sentences:-
We are going to the cinema and spending an evening at the opera.
The lending library closes at 7pm, but the reading rooms stay open until 9pm.
Other conjunctions, however, are used to subordinate one clause (the subclause) to the other (the main clause). The following pairs of sentences illustrate the difference between coordinating and subordinating conjunctions:-

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- **With specific times of day, or mealtimes:**

He doesn't like driving at night.
I'll go shopping at lunchtime.
I like to read the children a story at bedtime.

- **In certain fixed expressions which refer to specific points in time:**

Are you leaving at the weekend?**
She's working at the moment.
He's unavailable at present.
I'll finish the course at the end of April.
We arrived at the same time.
**Note that in American English, on the weekend is the correct form.

The preposition in is used in the following descriptions of time:



- **With months, years, seasons, and longer periods of time:**

I was born in 1965.
We're going to visit them in May.
The pool is closed in winter.
He was famous in the 1980's.
The play is set in the Middle Ages.
They've done work for me in the past.

- **With periods of time during the day:**

He's leaving in the morning.
She usually has a sleep in the afternoon(s).
I tried to work in the evening.

- **To describe the amount of time needed to do something:**

They managed to finish the job in two weeks.
You can travel there and back in a day.

- **To indicate when something will happen in the future:**

She'll be ready in a few minutes.
He's gone away but he'll be back in a couple of days.

The preposition on is used in the following descriptions of time:

- **With days of the week, and parts of days of the week:**

I'll see you on Friday.
She usually works on Mondays.
We're going to the theatre on Wednesday evening.
(Note that in spoken English, on is often omitted in this context, e.g.: I'll see you Friday.)

- **With dates:**

The interview is on 29th April.
He was born on February 14th 1995.

2 Prepositions of place

The preposition at is used in the following descriptions of place/position:

- **With specific places/points in space:**

Angie's still at home.
I'll meet you at reception.
There's a man at the door.
I saw her standing at the bus stop.
Turn right at the traffic lights.
The index is at the back of the book.
Write your name at the top of each page.

- **With public places and shops:**



Jane's at the dentist/hairdresser.
I studied German at college/school/university.
Shall I meet you at the station?
We bought some bread at the supermarket.

- **With addresses:**

They live at 70, Duncombe Place.

- **With events:**

I met her at last year's conference.
She wasn't at Simon's party.

The preposition on is used in the following descriptions of place/position:

- **With surfaces, or things that can be thought of as surfaces:**

The letter is on my desk.
There was a beautiful painting on the wall.
The toy department is on the first floor.
Write the number down on a piece of paper.

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